

Chapter 8 Illustrative Cases of Nationalist State Leaders and Violent Conflict

Abstract

This chapter illustrates the book's theory of leader nationalism through nine comparative case studies spanning both democratic and authoritarian regimes. It argues that nationalist legitimization increases the likelihood of violent conflict when leaders define the nation in exclusionary terms, portray internal or external groups as existential threats, and publicly commit themselves to nationalist objectives that make compromise politically costly. Under these conditions, nationalist commitments lower the threshold for coercion, encourage military escalation, and make confrontational policies increasingly attractive instruments of political rule. Examining the leadership of Adolf Hitler, Vladimir Putin, Xi Jinping, Slobodan Milošević, Benito Mussolini, Donald Trump, Benjamin Netanyahu, Narendra Modi, and Recep Tayyip Erdoğan, the chapter demonstrates how leader nationalism contributes to diverse forms of political violence, including interstate war, civil conflict, ethnic cleansing, domestic repression, territorial revisionism, and democratic backsliding. Although nationalism alone does not determine conflict outcomes, the comparative evidence shows that embedding political legitimacy in nationalist commitments systematically reshapes leaders' strategic incentives. When rulers derive their authority from defending a narrowly defined national community, coercion becomes a politically rewarding means of preserving legitimacy, while restraint and compromise become increasingly costly. The result is a heightened risk of violent escalation across a wide range of political and institutional contexts.